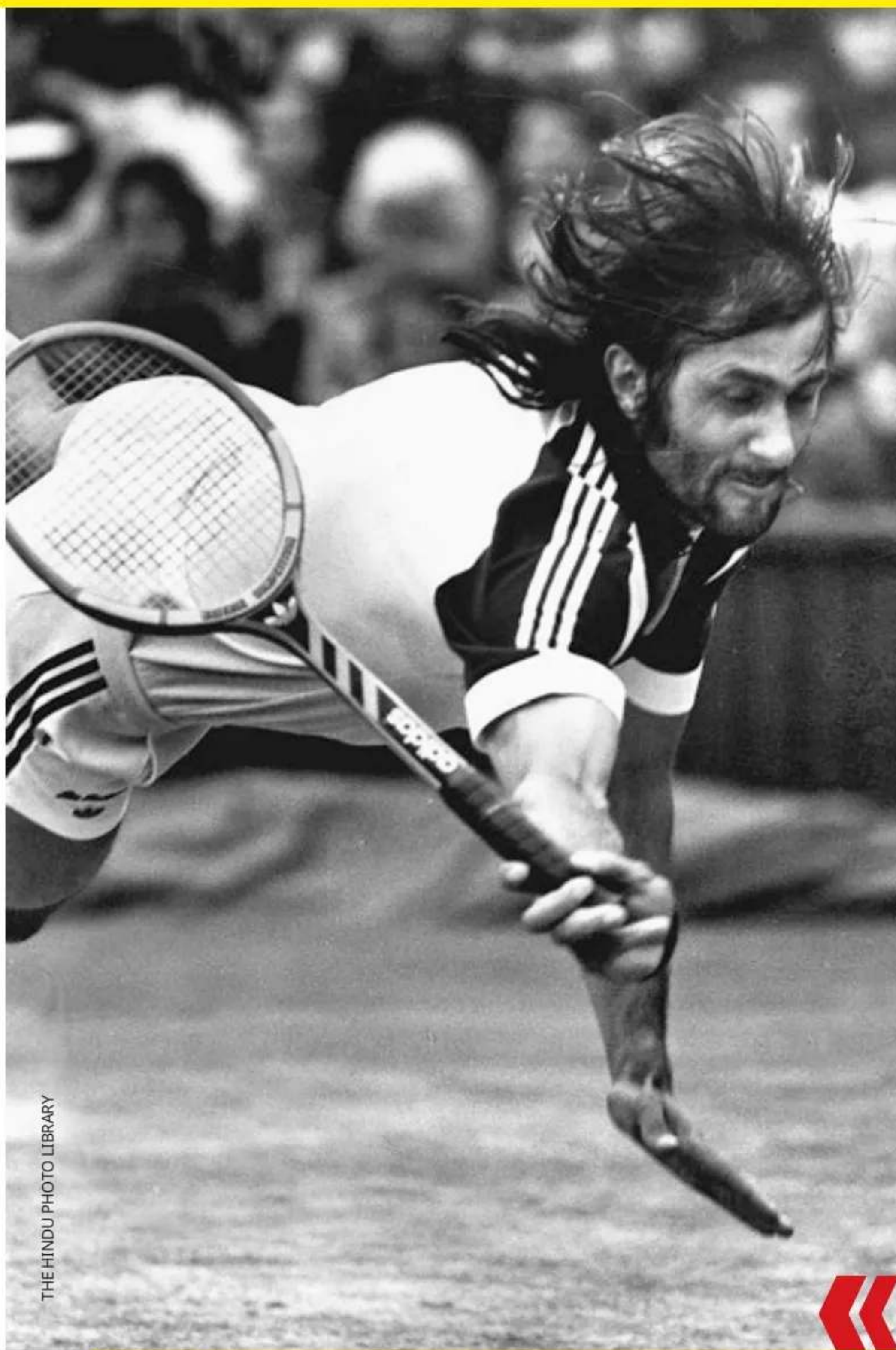




THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

NOT SINCE FRANKIE KOVACS HAD BIG-TIME TENNIS WITNESSED ANYTHING LIKE THE BUFFOONERY OF ILIE NASTASE IN THE 1970S

feathery drop shots, and clever angles. The artist was painting a masterpiece on the terre battue in Paris.

Ahead 6-3, 6-2, 1-1, the high-strung New Yorker angrily grabbed a TV cameraman's headset that was emitting loud noise, yelled

"Shut up!" and threw it aside. Most of the already pro-Lendl crowd of 18,000 started booing and whistling. McEnroe lost his poise, the momentum, and eventually the final 3-6, 2-6, 6-4, 7-5, 7-5.

"It was the worst loss of my life, a devastating defeat: Sometimes it still

keeps me up at nights," McEnroe confided in his 2002 autobiography, *You Cannot Be Serious*. "It's even tough for me now to do the commentary at the French — I'll often have one or two days when I literally feel sick to my stomach just at being there and thinking about that match. Thinking of what I threw away, and how different my life would've been if I'd won."

Ever since the first Wimbledon staged in 1877, talented showmen have had to navigate the tension Elizabeth Wilson described in a sport where split-second decisions can make the difference between victory and defeat. It's a truism that sports — especially tennis — reveal character as much as build character.

The mostly forgotten Frankie Kovacs attests to that. Nicknamed the 'Clown Prince of Tennis,' the handsome 6'4" Kovacs became notorious for crowd-pleasing antics like tossing three balls in the air to serve, then hitting one. He once did it on match point and hit an ace. The record books show the Californian reached the final of the 1941 U.S. National Championships (now the US Open) and defeated Bobby Riggs in 29 of their 64 amateur and pro matches.

Despite his considerable gifts — most notably, a powerful classic backhand considered second only to that of 1930s superstar Don Budge — he was remembered "as the greatest player never to win anything" of importance. In 1941, Budge said, "When Kovacs forgets his horseplay ... there's nobody he can't beat." Frankie's lame response: "When I get grim on the court, I dump the ball into the net or drive it over the fence. I can't stand the strain of being tense. ... I've got to have laughs to play good tennis."

The Bucharest buffoon

Not since Kovacs had big-time tennis witnessed anything like the buffoonery of Ilie Nastase (left) in the 1970s. Although Nastase, a superb athlete with a dazzling array of shots, won the French, Italian, and US Opens plus three Slam doubles titles (two with Connors and one with Ion